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On the image size front, we had the Sharp XR-10S and Epson EMP-S3 capable of projecting an image up to 300 inches large, while the Acer PD-115 and Hitachi CP-RS55 managed only 200 inches. What's notable is the fact that we had LCDs such as the Epson EMP-S3, which managed 1600 lumens with a 135 W lamp rating, while DLPs such as the Sharp XR-10S offered a 2000 lumen output at 270 W consumption by the lamp. The LCDs are clearly more efficient when it comes to the brightness-to-wattage ratio. All the projectors we tested had a native 4:3 aspect ratio, which can be scaled to the 16:9 required by DVDs—at the loss of screen space.

As expected, the DLPs totally trounced their LCD counterparts when it came to contrast ratios. All the DLPs in this segment sported a high contrast ratio of 2000:1 as opposed to the measly 500:1 and 300:1 offered by the Epson and Hitachi respectively. As a fallout, the black levels offered by both the LCDs were below par, to say the least.

When it came to the aesthetic appeal of the projectors, the Hitachi CP-RS55 exudes class with its silver finish and a slim profile with contoured edges. Its discreet buttons and everything placed flush with its body goes well with the Hitachi minimalist theme. This was, beyond a doubt, the most appealing projector we tested. Even though the Sharp XR-10S was the bulkiest of the lot, it still had a brilliant design approach making good use of contours and bevelled edges to balance its bulkiness.

The BenQ MP610 is the aesthetic equivalent of a brick; an ugly brick at that, with a cheap, boring black finish. The lines, edges, button placement

to reproduce intricate details and coloured lighting effects. The *Spirit* DVD had a flat-shaded animation that helped us to focus on a projector's absolute colour accuracy. Any colour imperfections and gradation problems were conspicuous with this DVD.

Movie Test

A movie test is significant because it transcends the major differentiating factor of resolution, because movies themselves have a fixed lower resolution. This allows us to evaluate the absolute image quality irrespective of the native resolution of a projector creating a level-ground across all segments.

No professional video test can be complete without the *Saving Private Ryan* and *Gladiator* DVDs. We had extremely rare, limited signature editions of the same, which feature phenomenal mastering quality, absent on the regular prints. *Gladiator* can pretty much bring any display system to its knees with the amount of resolution detail it holds, and features very hard-to-render scenes with great colour complexity. *Saving Private Ryan* is the industry standard benchmark when it comes to gauging the black-level detail,

and its wide array of muted colours stress any video system when it comes to accuracy of fine colour gradation.

Both of them have certain key areas where the colour wheel effect of DLPs can be easily apparent, if present. Another DVD used to test the projectors was *Corrs Unplugged*, which has close camera angles of the performers. We used it to check the skin tone accuracy of the projector. Its muted colours with great black scaling are instrumental in loading the DLP projection system enough to show their inherent flaws. This also has a high dynamic range of lighting in each frame, which amplifies any colour noise and intensity scaling problems.

However, the most significant was the *Corrs Live in London* DVD, which has the most amazing colour complexity you'll ever find, with a rainbow spectrum of volumetric lighting, lens flares, halos and an onstage back panel with ultra-bright psychedelic lighting effects. There are passages where the screen goes into extreme intensity of colours replete with a staggering array of colour blending. In fact, just one projector was able to give acceptable levels of colour accuracy with this DVD!

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